



Partly sunny 82/59 • Tomorrow: Showers 80/54 **B16**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, APRIL 23, 2026 • \$4



JULIA DEMAREE NIKHINSON/AP

Construction at the site of the former East Wing of the White House is seen from the Washington Monument on Monday.

Trump's secret terms for ballroom donors revealed

BY JONATHAN EDWARDS
AND DAN DIAMOND

The Trump administration's contract governing hundreds of millions of dollars in private donations to build President Donald Trump's White House ballroom shields donors' identities, excludes the White House from conflict of interest protections and was disclosed only after a lawsuit and a judge's order, records ob-

Judge ordered release of agreement governing gifts for \$400 million project

tained by The Washington Post show.

The agreement establishing the legal and financial framework for the planned \$400 million under-

taking — the most significant change to the White House in decades — was signed in early October, less than two weeks before demolition crews started destroying the East Wing. Public Citizen, a government watchdog organization, sued to obtain the contract between the White House, the National Park Service and the Trust for the National Mall, the nonprofit managing donations for the project, and

shared the document with The Post.

"The Trump administration's failure to disclose this contract was flatly unlawful," said Wendy Liu, a Public Citizen attorney and lead counsel on the lawsuit, filed after the Park Service and the Interior Department failed to fulfill a public records request for the document. "The American people are entitled to transparency over

SEE **BALLROOM** ON **A7**

No payoff for GOP in tit-for-tat map battle

Trump team defends redistricting offensive in wake of Virginia defeat

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF

President Donald Trump's political team is defending its push to redraw congressional districts mid-decade, a break from historical practice that provoked partisan retaliation, cost hundreds of millions of dollars and, so far, has left Republicans no better positioned to retain the House.

Virginia voters set back Trump's effort on Tuesday by approving a new map that shifts four seats toward Democrats. Some Republicans are now openly questioning the wisdom of opening this new front in partisan trench warfare since Trump pressured the Texas GOP last year to redistrict for a second time since the latest census.

The ensuing bouts between blue and red states have improved Democrats' prospects in nine districts nationwide compared to eight or nine for Republicans, endangering GOP control of Congress as polls show public confidence declining in Trump's handling of the economy and the war

SEE **VIRGINIA** ON **A6**

Takeaways: Here's what Virginia's vote means for the midterms. **A6**

New maps: A before-and-after look at redrawn districts in Virginia. **B12**

China tightens grip on AI firms that try to exit

BY REBECCA TAN
AND LYRIC LI

SINGAPORE — Facing fierce competition with the United States over artificial intelligence, Chinese authorities are taking stronger steps to try to stop rising AI start-ups from leaving the country to seek capital and markets in the West, according to a dozen people working in the sector inside and outside China.

Beijing sent its most overt warning shot last month when it ordered the Chinese founders of an AI company, Manus AI, not to exit the country while it investigates whether the company complied with export controls in the lead-up to its exit from China and sale to Meta.

Private Investment in AI (2025)

Private investment in AI in the U.S. was more than 23 times the amount in China.



Source: Stanford AI Index Report 2026

LYRIC LI/THE WASHINGTON POST

Authorities have gone beyond Manus, however, directly warning at least one other prominent AI firm, MiroMind, not to send valuable talent and research out of China, according to two employees and a person close to the company, who like some others interviewed for this report spoke

on the condition of anonymity for fear of government reprisal. MiroMind, which says it trains sophisticated AI programs capable of "deep reasoning," did not respond to requests for comment.

The Chinese government's efforts around MiroMind and some

SEE **CHINA** ON **A12**



MAXINE WALLACE/THE WASHINGTON POST

Grilled on the Hill

Two top GOP senators who are physicians pressed Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. about his controversial record on vaccines in their first public meeting in over seven months. **Story, A6**

Six months to rid Hormuz of mines, Pentagon assesses

OIL PRICES COULD BE HIGH LATE INTO YEAR

Unpopular conflict has fractured Trump's base

BY DAN LAMOTHE,
NOAH ROBERTSON
AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

It could take six months to fully clear the Strait of Hormuz of mines deployed by the Iranian military, and any such operation is unlikely to be carried out until the U.S. war with Iran ends, the Pentagon has informed Congress — an assessment that means the conflict's economic impact could extend late into this year or beyond.

A senior Defense Department official shared the estimate during a classified briefing Tuesday for members of the House Armed Services Committee, said three officials familiar with the discussion. The timeline — met with frustration by Democrats and Republicans alike, two of these people said — is the latest sign that gasoline and oil prices could remain elevated long after any peace deal is reached.

Beyond any economic ramifications, such an outcome also

could have significant implications politically in the United States — particularly for Republicans — as November's midterm elections draw near. President Donald Trump's decision to start the war has proved unpopular with most Americans, recent polls have shown, and it has fractured his political base, which voted him into office based in part on his repeated promises to avoid foreign military entanglements and focus more on domestic issues.

On Wednesday, the average cost of a gallon of gas in the United States was \$4.02, according to AAA, up from \$2.98 just before the war began in February. Trump has vacillated on the question of when gas prices may come down, saying this month that they "could be the same or maybe a little bit higher" by the midterms before declaring that they would be "much lower" before the election. His treasury secretary, Scott Bessent, has said it could be late September before "we can have \$3 gas again."

Three officials, speaking on the condition of anonymity because of the discussion's sensitivity, said lawmakers were told that Iran may have emplaced 20 or more mines in and around the Strait of Hormuz, a vital waterway for the

SEE **IRAN** ON **A9**

Trump weighs tradeoffs that gave Obama grief

Sticking points are sanctions, enrichment, risk of empowering Iran

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

Billions in frozen assets may be handed back to Iran. Agreements to limit Tehran's nuclear program may eventually expire. And some of the same hard-line leaders who crushed nationwide protests in January could end up better-resourced than they were before President Donald Trump unleashed crushing airstrikes more than seven weeks ago.

After a decade of fiercely attacking a previous deal with Iran, Trump, pursuing a way out of a war he launched, has authorized U.S. negotiators to consider a bargain that involves many of the

same trade-offs one of his predecessors confronted.

Though talks appear paused for now following Trump's decision on Tuesday to extend the ceasefire indefinitely while Iran comes up with a "unified proposal," the president will likely face the same challenges no matter when negotiators eventually sit down with each other.

With the conflict on hold, the uneasy truce could solidify. But shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has not returned to normal levels amid a continuing U.S. blockade of Iranian ports and Iran's assertion of control over the shipping lanes. That has created a drag on global energy markets. Iran retains control over its trove of highly enriched uranium, which Trump has previously said

SEE **TALKS** ON **A11**

Strait of Hormuz: Iran says it took two ships hours after extension. **A9**

Phelan out as secretary of Navy after 13 months

Officials say billionaire and Trump donor clashed repeatedly with Hegseth

BY DAN LAMOTHE,
TARA COPP
AND NOAH ROBERTSON

Navy Secretary John Phelan will depart the Trump administration "effective immediately," officials said Wednesday evening, an abrupt exit after 13 tumultuous months at the Pentagon.

Sean Parnell, a spokesman for Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, announced the news on social media, saying that Hegseth and Deputy Defense Secretary Steve Feinberg wished Phelan well.

Five officials said that Phelan, a billionaire art collector and fundraiser for President Donald Trump's reelection campaign, was forced out after repeated clashes with both Hegseth and Feinberg over his management of shipbuilding and a variety of other issues. One administration official, who like some others spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the issue's sensitivity, said Phelan was asked to step down.

Spokespeople for Hegseth and Feinberg did not respond to questions about the move. Spokespeople for Phelan and the White House referred questions back to Hegseth's office.

Navy Undersecretary Hung Cao, a Navy veteran and former candidate for House and Senate seats in Virginia, will become the

SEE **NAVY** ON **A11**

IN THE NEWS

'State of the air report' More than 150 million people across the United States, including nearly half the nation's children, live in areas affected by harmful levels of air pollution. **A2**

Georgia Democrat dies at 80 Rep. David Scott had served in the U.S. House since 2003 and was seeking a 13th term. **A3**

THE NATION **The CDC** won't publish a report showing covid shots cut the likelihood of hospital visits. **A3** **A man** in Louisiana was charged with lying to police about the gun used by a mass killer. **A3**

THE WORLD **The White House** has suspended some deliveries of U.S. currency to Iraq. **A10** **Ukraine** is set to get a \$105 billion loan as Hungary drops its opposition. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **Moderna** is launching a clinical trial of a shot to combat bird flu after HHS had canceled hundreds of millions in vaccine funding. **A16** **Devin Nunes**, a former congressman, is leaving as CEO of Trump's media company after more than four years. **A16**

STYLE **Anti-Trump** guerrilla artists and anonymous collectives are flourishing in Washington. **B1**

SPORTS **Liam Rosenior** was fired as Chelsea manager after a troubling Premier League run of five losses without scoring a goal. **B7**

THE REGION **The D.C. mayor** again criticized lawmakers for not immediately extending a curfew to address large tent gatherings. **B12**

LOCAL LIVING **Why can't we** sit alone with our thoughts? A survey shows Americans listen to nearly four hours of audio a day.

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